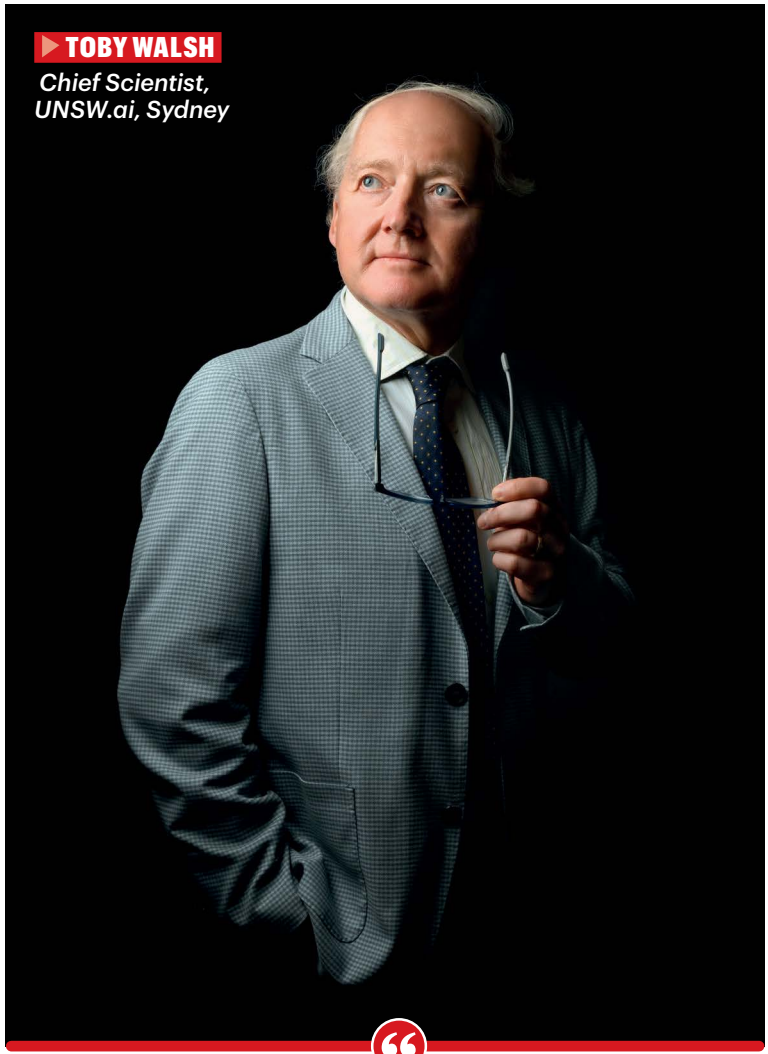
AI FOR ALL



TOBY WALSH
Chief Scientist, UNSW.ai, Sydney

What really surprises me is the rate at which the field is unfolding...a billion dollars is being spent on AI every day around the world. We've never seen that scale of investment in one technology ever before

You need not be too worried today about machines taking over... computers don't have any initiative of their own. But you do have to worry that humans are going to direct the technologies in ways that could be harmful

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- **AI is gobbling up 20% of the entire global R&D budget**
- **Argument that regulation stifles innovation is a myth**
- **To harness the power of AI, technology should be in the hands of everyone**

The analogy that Toby Walsh likes to use for Artificial Intelligence (AI) is that of electricity. It's everywhere, even in the remotest corners. But what's now seen as a universal necessity too was once the monopoly of a few who had the first-mover advantage, he pointed out at the India Today Conclave. "AI is going to be the same," said Walsh, a chief scientist at the University of New South Wales, who has been working in the field of AI for four decades. In the long term, however, he reckons the winner in the AI landscape won't be "one super-duper" company or the ones with the deepest pockets. India, he added, could "do very well" if it plays its cards right because it has both the brainpower and the data—the two ingredients necessary for AI.

But should we be worried about machines taking over? Walsh, who has authored several books on AI, is not among those alarmists. "At the moment, machines do exactly what we tell them to do," he explained. His worry, instead, is about humans. In the wrong hands, AI could supercharge "misinformation and disinformation" much more than social media did. In the process, it could transform the nature of warfare and democracy itself, he fears. To harness the power of AI, Walsh said technology should be in the hands of everyone and not just the people in Silicon Valley "who are making those fundamental decisions about what the future will be like".

"Let's not forget. There are many technologies we have regulated as a planet," he pointed out, referring to nuclear, chemical and biological weapons. Therefore, he thinks that the argument of tech companies that regulation necessarily stifles innovation is "a bit of a myth." ■